

B894: Dissertation (HRM)

Do SHRM Signalling Practices, Compared to Conventional HRM
Approaches, Affect How Neurodivergent Employees Perceive the Employee
Journey?

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1.10.1 JEL Classifications

To navigate the literature, I shall be using several JEL codes to classify my MSc in HRM dissertation, these codes are:

JEL CODE	PRIMARY/SECONDARY CATEGORIES
J24	Human Capital; Skills; Occupational Choice; Labor Productivity
J71	Labor Discrimination
D82	Asymmetric and Private Information; Signalling
D83	Search; Learning; Information and Knowledge; Communication; Beliefs
D86	Economics of Contract: Theory
D90	Micro-Based Behavioural Economics
M51	Personnel Economics; Executive Compensation
M54	Labor Management; Industrial Relations
I12	Health Behaviour; Health Economics
I14	Health and Inequality

The TMA 1 assignment began here – Revisions are included in red

1.11 Background to the Topic

Questions pertaining to the nature of access to employment opportunities for Autistic adults can vary from achieving optimal methods for disclosing neuroinclusive interview accommodation to the more critical issue involving relational concepts of interpreting bereavement and loss in the context of the workplace (Park, 1998). Published research on access to employment is well advanced in uncovering how the adoption of certain agreed and pre-defined strategies by employers can in a sense influence how employers manage the productive contribution of adults with Autism, these have been uncovered by academics using known approaches such as longitudinal or cohort studies, short-term investigations and re-analyses of contemporary data (Morgan, 1996).

It is timely that this opportunity to prepare a MSc dissertation thesis has emerged, partly due to the recency of the Buckland Review which was published by Autistica in early 2024 under the leadership of the then Conservative Prime Minister, the Rt. Hon Rishi Sunak and partly due to the author's work as a Royal Economic Society independent researcher and Consultant Director, working alongside the Opening Doors Initiative (Business in the Community, 2026) to develop employment opportunities for people from disadvantaged communities across Britain. Since the end of the Conservative Party's 14-year tenure in office in 2024, the rise in what has come to be known as youth who are not in employment, education or training

(NEETs, essentially) has somewhat subsided but since the outcome of the Buckland Review and its subsequent findings concerning the employment prospects for Autistic adults (that is, 7 in 10 are not in gainful employment across the country), further research has been conducted by Miller and Doyle (2025) which forms the basis of how employer's *deconstruct* the various approaches taken when attracting the aforementioned 7 in 10 adults with Autism as applicants to open roles and by accommodating their interest during recruitment activities, without employing specific and targeted recruitment campaigns which require candidates to come forward and identify their conditions at the outset of the process. Dr. Nancy Doyle is a prolific campaigner for neurodivergence in the workplace who has previously written an online opinion piece for Genius Within, a UK community interest company, on the subject of the Sir Charlie Mayfield Review (Doyle, 2025). The Mayfield Review and the work of Miller and Doyle (2025) will feature throughout this dissertation.

The aforementioned is important for several reasons, not least for the intrinsic motivation of the employee but also on grounds of fairness and positive discrimination. I am aiming to study how neurodiverse applicants perceive SHRM and how SHRM approaches, which are inherently focused on creating competitive advantage link to recruitment signalling during the applicant journey. I am hoping to investigate several, which will form the backbone of the research study, and which will either confirm the work of Miller and Doyle (2025) or reject the premise of their recent research study using a deductive methodology. I also plan to extend Miller and Doyle's work to study anonymous responses from neurotypical and neurodiverse applicants.

1.11.1 Four Lines of Enquiry

Q1: What is the sub-game optimal signal (in a game of separating or pooling equilibrium) an employer should send to all applicants in order to be considered neuroinclusive? Also, at what level of signal does an employer who signals acceptance of a neurodiverse condition, become accepted by a neurodiverse applicant?

Q2: What proportion of exertion should be given to ensure reasonable adjustments are afforded to all neurodiverse applicants who are successful during the interview process and what proportion of exertion should be afforded to ensuring a plurality of ethnicities are duly and adequate engaged within that very same recruitment process?

Q3: In a separating equilibrium with known payoffs, and standard assumptions (complete information and perfect monitoring), how do employers successfully navigate a many-to-one "lottery" scenario, using the offered wage as an optimal signal or as a navigating mechanism?

Q4: Can the use of artificial intelligence inspire a Nash outcome to occur that is Pareto-optimal, where the set wage and a signal for a neuroinclusive working environment are both revealed by the employer and accepted by the applicant?

1.12 Introduction

Given that recent research demonstrates how neuroinclusive teams can be 30% more productive than those which do not include neurodiverse employees (NatWest Mentor, 2025), and with Gen Z entering the workforce – over 50% of whom have some sort of neurodivergent condition² - either Autism Spectrum Disorder or Bipolar Disorder (Forbes Magazine, 2025), the broad research topic I have selected to follow for this module is a contemporary problem with its roots in a recent report (Youth Future's Foundation, 2025). As an interdisciplinary topic, this thesis is partly covered by *signalling* (psychology), *applicant attraction* (HRM), *employee wellbeing* (HRM) and *labour market analysis* (game theory).

As I am deeply intrigued by the sort of opportunities available to young and neurodiverse adult applicants and how these opportunities are perceived by those who apply, I have chosen a topic that investigates an instance and prevalent gap in the literature on hiring technology and perceptions of recruitment processes by neurodiverse applicants (Miller and Doyle, 2025). I have devised a set of five hypothesis to outline the

² I define two specific conditions in-scope of this study: Autism and Bipolar Disorder.

direction which I would like the research to follow, and which resulted in the research question I have settled on.

1.13 Research Methodology

From the very outset I will be aiming to utilise a deductive approach for this MSc in HRM research study (which incorporates sentiment analysis and an open-ended questionnaire to answer the question as to how neurodiverse applicants can best be catered for in) by conducting empirical analysis of a diverse range of datasets including non-sensitive HR data. The research questionnaire is available (in draft) to view [here](#) and resumes the research topic where (Miller and Doyle, 2025) ended, although the topic of discussion has been realigned to include artificial intelligence, the fundamental assertions are the same. The following hypotheses are subject to supervisory changes and will be honed and amended as and when new information in the literature is discovered, reviewed and internalised. In order, these initial hypotheses read as follows:

Hypothesis 1: Neurodiverse workers apply only to firms who signal intent to accommodate

Hypothesis 2: Firms choose to allocate resources between signalling neurodiversity and DEI initiatives

Hypothesis 3: Firms signalling higher average wages tend to be less neuroinclusive relatively

Hypothesis 4: Firms harnessing the power of AI can achieve high wages be optimally neuroinclusive

These hypotheses refer to the research designed by Chang and Chin (2018) in their paper on online ratings and signalling and act as a starting point for further hypotheses.

1.13.1 Data Sources

Data sources for this project will use data from Understanding Society (UKHLS), the Life Opportunities Survey (Waves 1-3); and the OECD Employment & Labour Market Statistics (each dataset from 2010-2015).

Selected variables: 'jbatt' which is a variable proxy representing the survey response concerning the question about the main attraction of one's current job, 'jwbs2_dv' which is a job-related depression scale, and finally a variable proxy for 'social contract' which is derived from the Life Opportunities Survey, where the respondent identifies if they have a health condition, impairment or other illness (this is part of a longitudinal dataset).

Independent Variables (Employees)	Representation
Main attraction of current job	'J'
Job-related Depression scale	(1 - D)
Social contract (health condition)	'S'
Reason for sickness absence	0 or 1

Other selected variables: We assume the employer observes productivity of current workers, profitability of their business unit, and thereafter sets its offered wage above the market wage as this is a proven method of ensuring the avoidance of workers who are likely to shirk or who signal low productivity levels (Shapiro and Stiglitz).

Independent Variables (Applicants)	Representation
Productivity signalled by each new worker	U^*
Profitability of the business	Simply 'H' or $(P \times Q)$
Shirking likelihood of each applicant	$(1 - U)$
Above market wage level	$1 + W \times (H) / U$

1.14 The Topic's Importance to the Literature

The importance of the research survey cannot be understated. Specifically, the topic is important because it seeks to enquire into how diverse job applicants perceive their roles in the organization prior to being onboarded as employees (in other words, it asks how *neurodiverse* applicants interact as job candidates) through the proxy of website recruiting activities. The seminal applied instance of this research topic is the online ratings and HRM signalling paper pioneered by Chang and Chin (2018) who test evidence to investigate the hypothesis that three things are likely to occur prior to onboarding:

1. A high-commitment HRM strategy is pursued and that firms conduct recruitment via a website
2. The firm may initiate a signal to the receiver via this website about its high-commitment HRM strategy
3. This signal initiates an effect on the employees' online ratings.

1.14.1 The Model

Assume then that given the inclusion of pre-existing variables, it is possible to amalgamate datasets from various third-party sources. What then can the relationship be argued to be between employer and the interests of the applicant or employee?

As such, the authors (Chang and Chin, 2018) argue for five important hypotheses which form the starting point for this study:

- 1) Firms with more high-commitment HRM will signal more HRM information on websites
- 2) Firms signalling more HRM information on websites will experience a trend of more applications
- 3) Firms' signalling of HRM information on websites fully mediates the effect of the firms' commitment HRM on recruitment
- 4) Firms' actual HRM influences employees after experience outcomes such that firms' commitment HRM will increase online ratings
- 5) Firms' signalling of HRM will not increase an employees' online ratings if the effect of commitment HRM (on recruitment) is controlled

My research will aim to extend a gap on this topic by focusing on firm expenditure, capabilities and resources, asking a question not currently addressed by the literature on signalling – how these factors affect competitive advantage given the specific context of attribution theory (Guest, 2021).

1.15 Timeline for Completion and Next Steps

Out of scope: I will be conducting a literature review for B894 which will be completed in February 2026, I do not intend to look at any sort of data or make any requests for data access until ethical approval has been given for my MSc research question and methodological design.

Within Scope: I will begin to map the hypotheses using sources such as Overton.io and others that have been identified; and assuming the research question can be scrutinised on an ongoing basis, it will then be possible to review the available literature, filter through and arrange such information into formats which will allow me to revise the hypotheses (cited above), and hopefully make use of both quantitative methods such as sentiment analysis and indeed qualitative analysis such as a survey or questionnaire.

The TMA 2 assignment begins here

1.16 Introduction to TMA 2 – Literature Review

As SHRM (specifically, RBV) is a very interdisciplinary subject when it comes to research that defines theory - I will be sourcing information on the following subtopics from three highly reliable contemporary literature sources (EBSCOhost Research Databases, JSTOR, Open University Library and Google Scholar). My intention is to source academic peer-reviewed literature published roughly between 2010 – 2025 in terms of timelines (the literature effectively narrates on the problem which can be traced back to about 2011 in reports so, there's about a 8–10-year gap where the problem surfaces and the seminal papers focused on analysing the problem begin to emerge in the literature). However, there may be exceptions to this timeline as per the theoretical work of Coles and Treble (1993) or the earlier theoretical work by Rynes and Barber (1990). Though the three selected sources indeed do store great literature on each subtopic, I may require policy infographics, charts and vital published statistics which will also be important to this study's objective. I will therefore be actively seeking NGO and government reports drawn from Overton.io, where such information may be found.

1.17 Mapping Relevant Subtopics

Employment Opportunities: According to Sir Robert Buckland's Autism and Employment Review published alongside Autistica on the employment of sufferers on the ASD spectrum, only 3 in 10 people with ASD are gainfully employed, the remaining 7 in 10 of the UK's population are unemployed or underemployed. This figure rises to 8 in 10 on a worldwide basis (Davies et. al. 2023).

Applicant Attraction: A recent study on applicant attraction by Dutta and Mishra (2021) have focused on Gen-Z and millennial generation cohorts in the context of the Indian sub-continent.

Signalling Theory: The seminal work on signalling is found in Spence (1973) however, since this paper was published there have been numerous attempts to assign and apply signalling theory to the context of the hiring process.

1.18 Conducting Gap Analysis

1.19 Organising the Literature Review

As part of the planning process, I shall spend time gathering articles from a number of relevant online databases which host peer-reviewed journals. These are listed below under the "Source" column. I plan to gather a minimum of five articles from each of the clear *subtopics*, acting as search protocol and using the jigsaw format as structure (University of Hull Library, 2025).

How does signalling affect a strategic HRM approach? Roehl stipulates this contention is analogous to the conflict as seen in psychological contract theory, arguing that an organization's signal – through its communications strategy (Eppler *et.al.*, 2026) and its choice of HR system, can have a variation of impacts on the perception of the employee (Roehl, 2019).

Familiar themes from Roehl (2019)'s article:

- The notion that SHRM can influence attitudinal and behavioural reactions (Lepak *et. al* and Bowen and Ostroff) is analogous to the findings of an article by Morris *et. al.* (1993) on attitudinal and behavioural commitments.

1. Applicant Attraction

Source	Name of Journal / Book	Scoped Articles
Emerald	Personnel Review	Celani and Singh (2011)
JSTOR	Academy of Management Review	Rynes and Barber (1990)

2. Neurodiversity (Bipolar and Autism - Diversity and Inclusion)

Source	Name of Journal / Book	Scoped Articles
Wiley Online	The Scandinavian Journal of Econ	Sarsons (2024)
Wiley Online	Human Resource Management	Lup and Canonico (2024)
Sage Journals	Autism	Davies et. al. (2023)

3. Recruitment and Selection (Game Theory and Signalling Theory)

Source	Name of Journal / Book	Scoped Articles
Emerald	Personnel Review	Younis & Hammad (2021)
Wiley Online	The Scandinavian Journal of Econ	Barmby, Sessions & Treble (1994)
Emerald	Personnel Review	Celani & Singh (2011)
Wiley Online	Journal of Occupational & Org Psychology	Miller & Doyle (2025)
Wiley Online	Human Resource Management Journal	Guest et. al. (2021)
Elsevier	Journal of Business Research	Chang & Chin (2018)
JSTOR	The Quarterly Journal of Econ	Spence (1973)
EBSCO Host	Academy of Management Journal	Jones et. al. (2014)

1.19.1 Sufficient Signalling Given Neurodiverse Conditions

This paper begins with a general overview of how SHRM signalling serves the needs of adults with Autism.

1.19.2 Signalling in the Context of the ‘Many-to-One’ Hiring Lottery

Here, in the view of Spence (1973) the notion of hiring is made analogous to the rationale of purchasing a ticket for a lottery draw, which itself is a problematic notion due to the euphemisms of risk, value and eventual loss being invoked. This rationale of adopting such a gamble is best described per a model composed by Brown and Sessions (2004). Spence argues that there is often an element of informational asymmetry pertaining to full knowledge of the average worker’s capability in the job prior to such a lottery concept being invoked. Assuming the lottery concept is associated with information that is rarely fully disseminated, an employer’s perception of this lottery gamble is what Spence (1973) defines as a “primary interest” due to the uncertainty involved in making the proposed hire when weighed against the wages offered by the employer to the worker as compensation for services rendered. When discussing the lottery, we speak here of a singular instance of a repeated game. The terms of reference adhered to by Spence, constitute very strict and formal belief system for his term sheet mapping the employer’s perception of the lottery process. There are two kinds of observable attributes mentioned in Spence’s article: Indices and signals (Spence, 1973; p. 357). The term “indices” refers to “immutable” attributes observed by the employer amongst participants in the hiring ‘lottery’, attributes such as race or sex. This is followed closely by the term “signals”, which references alterable

attributes or those which can be manipulated by the candidate, such as education and experience. For the purposes of Spence's research, age is considered as an alterable attribute and is therefore seen to be an index. Signals and indices are seen to be "parameters" in the conditional probability distribution reflecting the "beliefs" of an employer.

Navigating this landscape of DEI in recruitment can be oftentimes a complex pursuit. Upon reflection with some experience and exposure to high-level dialogue gained through the Business in the Community (BITC) Opening Doors program, it's fair and proper to infer proportionality. By this, I mean the idea that work is a lottery is not an appropriate lens to view employment dynamics. Much of the work found in the recommendations of the 2024 Autistica report authored in collaboration with Sir Robert Buckland KC can be supported by academic literature. If the Autistica report identifies the scenarios and problem faced by Autistic job applicants, then Miller and Doyle (2025) most certainly shed further light on this problematisation of a many-to-one 'lottery' scenario by providing what one might call a dialectical synthesis to the concerns highlighted in the report. According to Miller and Doyle (2025) the article mentions the theoretical framework of Khan et. al. (2023) whose literature review and empirical study on the topic is the only post-COVID era work used as authority, but the article also acknowledges that research in the area of inclusive signalling to neurodiverse applicants is relatively limited. When extending Khan et. al. (2023)'s ideas for further research in a HR context, Miller and Doyle (2025) apply a systems-based analysis of "signalling" theory (or rather a systematic approach based on academic literature) in the hiring and selection process to uncover a consummate view that the inclusion of the neurodiverse job applicant in the workplace is paramount. Both co-authors argue organisations should go *beyond* the business case for diversity in recruitment by making the process itself clearer.

One can divide the approach for achieving such an eventuality as follows. Firstly, Miller and Doyle treatise an argument in favour of neuroinclusive approaches by encouraging proactivity from the employer. The line of thinking goes: If an employer provides a list of 'frequently requested adjustments' then this action is therefore a proactive signal to candidates who may require such adjustments to participate in the process. A great example of how a high-growth firm's neurodiversity hiring approach can eliminate the bias of the interviewer, recruiter or hiring manager comes in the form of Microsoft recruitment and workplace accommodations (Microsoft, 2026). Likewise, by sufficiently educating recruitment staff and hiring managers involved in the act of recruitment and selection on what "neurodivergent *behaviours*" are, and by thereafter implementing a follow-up action: prioritising diversity, equity and inclusion over the Spencian view of hiring as a lottery, we arrive at a mechanism which appreciates neurodiversity as a recruitment priority. Critiques may argue this may create a consequentialist dependence on prior training investment.

1.19.3 Multi-Level Analyses and Consequentialist Values

In contrast to Miller and Doyle's pragmatism on the subject of signalling approaches, Celani and Singh (2011) have conducted an analysis of signalling theory from a multi-level perspective (with the use of 'contextual effects'). By multi-level, or multi-hierarchical (affecting various modes of the organisation; navigating the macro-level, the meso-level, through to the individual-level) the assessment of how recruitment-related signals is seen to reveal unknown characteristics of the organization becomes more stratified. The theory posited provides links between individual and organisation-level signals from recruitment activities. Links are made between market signals and instrumental or symbolic applicant inferences. Celani and Singh (2011) are concerned predominantly with outcomes (as opposed to the interest of Davies *et. al.* (2023) for example who are concerned with recruitment *methods* faced by Autistic adults. They therefore take up a consequentialist position (a position which derives itself from the moral philosophy of consequentialism). By introducing their topic in such a way, Celani and Singh conclude by challenging readers via invitation to study a gap in the

signalling literature ~ signalling from a recruiter perspective i.e. from the organisation's perspective. This means to imply that the organisation (recruiter or hiring manager) does indeed perceive and internalise what Spence (1973) defines as 'alterable' attributes (for instance, the highest level of education signalled by the candidate or the candidate's length of experience/number of promotions or career highlights). Signalling theory when viewed through the Spencian lens is therefore arguably either angst and menace on the one hand or catalyst and predicator on the other.

By contrasting the approaches of Celani and Singh (2011) with that of Miller and Doyle (2025) it's possible to observe how in hindsight both authors take completely opposing perspectives on signalling in the context of neurodiversity. Chang and Chin (2018) on the other hand define signalling less altruistically but as the communication of unique information or rather "the sending out of information that competitors cannot easily imitate" analysing HRM signalling on each firm's website over a three-year period. Signalling therefore becomes important in job markets where numerous employers compete to "increase market share". Chang and Chin (2018) stress the importance of firm actions and separating equilibrium (The Open University, 2026).

The work of David Guest has been prominent in HRM literature for well over 30+ years. In Guest (2021), the author studies the staff members of bank branches and primarily defines signalling theory as "communication *by* and *within* an organisation", in contrast to evidence from Laker *et. al.* (2025). Citing Bowen and Ostroff (2004) as part of an integrated framework to study attribution theory, Guest (2021) concludes that signalling theory is to be viewed as a "*distinctive*" approach to the HRM process. He acknowledges limitations of cross-sectional methodology and calls for longitudinal research approaches.

The article by Bowen and Ostroff (2004) is one which touches upon multi-level relationships between HRM and organisational performance through psychological "climate" as an example of higher-order social structures (other examples include organisational culture and organisational role structure, and organisational sensemaking (which is a design thinking principle). (p.205). Bowen and Ostroff (2004) highlight the additional importance of "social context theory" where formal roles are defined by organisational systems and "maintenance subsystems".

1.20 Discussion

Axiology which is the study of the science of value (Bahm, 2021) is indeed an important aspect to consider when developing a theoretical understanding of recruitment. Contextualising and internalising the scientific value of the process requires an understanding of the employer's brand value, and its positioning relative proximity to the preferences of ideal applicants and other organizations.

AI as an umbrella term for concepts machine learning, NLP, computer vision and other key algorithmic concepts. Some gaps certainly do exist in the form of "*minimal information*" available concerning the effects of bipolar depression in later life, one of the more pronounced gaps in the literature is the more recent focus on Artificial Intelligence ("AI") and employment balances for neurodivergent neurotypical applicants (Mirowska and Arsenyan, 2025; Smith *et. al.*, 2025) which assumes the capture of those who suffer from Bipolar I or II. AI has been argued to carry the potential to promote or affect various types of diversity, to avoid the consequence of overexposure to unconscious biases, and to help design more comprehensive signalling approaches to attract talent, recruit and retain new employees and to develop an overarching organisational focus on *cultural* diversity more generally. According to an open access paper by Chilunjika, *et. al.* (2022), gaps exist in the research on AI's application to HRM in the public sector.

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